Escalation Triggers and Customer Communication Standard

KARTWAY CUSTOMER OPERATIONS POLICY MANUAL
Document Ref: KW-POL-OP-042 Effective Date: 14 January 2025
Subject: Automated-to-Human Escalation Thresholds and Interaction Protocols Applies To: All Tier-1 Automated Systems, Virtual Assistants, and Tier-2 Human Support Agents

1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

1.1 This standard defines the mandatory operational triggers that require the immediate transfer of a customer interaction from the Kartway automated virtual assistant to a human support agent.
1.2 Compliance with these thresholds is mandatory for all customer-facing automated workflows. Failure to escalate within the prescribed turns constitutes a system compliance violation under Internal Audit Reference OP-2025-04.

2. MANDATORY ESCALATION TRIGGERS

An automated interaction must be transferred to a human agent within one (1) message turn upon the occurrence of any of the following events:

2.1 Explicit Request for a Human * Rule: If a customer explicitly requests human assistance using phrases including, but not limited to, *"talk to a person"*, *"human agent"*, *"real representative"*, or *"customer service"*, the automated system must cease automated resolution pathways immediately. * Action: Route the conversation to the Tier-2 General Queue within forty-five (45) seconds of the request.

2.2 Abusive Language * Rule: An interaction must be escalated if the customer uses profanity, targeted harassment, or discriminatory slurs directed at Kartway, its employees, or its delivery partners. * Action: Issue a single automated warning advising that abusive language violates the Kartway Community Standard (Policy KW-SEC-09). If the behavior persists on the subsequent message, route the interaction to the Tier-2 High-Priority Queue and flag the account for review by the Trust and Safety Unit managed by Sarah Jenkins.

2.3 Third Contact on the Same Issue * Rule: If the system detects that the customer has initiated three (3) distinct chat or email interactions regarding the same Order ID or underlying support ticket within a rolling fourteen (14) day window, automatic resolution is locked. * Action: Escalate directly to a Tier-2 Specialist assigned to the original ticket cluster.

2.4 Legal Action or Regulatory Complaints * Rule: Any mention of legal counsel, lawsuits, small claims court, or regulatory bodies (including, but not limited to, the Federal Trade Commission, State Attorney General, or equivalent national consumer protection agencies) triggers an immediate mandatory escalation. * Action: Route the ticket to the Legal Response Operations Queue supervised by Marcus Vance. Automated responses are strictly prohibited upon receipt of these keywords.

2.5 Physical Harm or Product Safety * Rule: Any reference to personal injury, property damage, chemical burns, choking hazards, lithium-ion battery failures, or malfunctioning electrical items must bypass standard workflows. * Action:

Transfer the session instantly to the Critical Incident Response Team (CIRT). The system must simultaneously dispatch an automated email to `safety-escalations@kartway-internal.com` containing the associated Order ID and unedited transcript.

2.6 Refunds Above the Automated Cap * Rule: The maximum refund value an automated system is authorized to issue without human verification is $50.00 USD (or regional currency equivalent). * Action: If a customer-requested refund, goodwill credit, or compensation claim exceeds $50.00 USD, the system must inform the customer that the request requires manual review and route the chat to the Billing and Finance Escalations Queue. Automated overrides of this cap are technically disabled via API restriction K-FIN-881.

3. REQUIRED TONE GUIDANCE FOR AUTOMATED SYSTEMS

3.1 Automated responses must remain objective, neutral, and solution-oriented at all times.
3.2 Emotional mirroring is prohibited. Systems must not adopt overly familiar, slang-heavy, or excessively dramatic language when a customer expresses distress.
3.3 The required phrasing structure for acknowledging customer frustration is limited to: *"I understand this situation has caused frustration, and I am connecting you with a human specialist to assist you further."*

4. PROHIBITION ON LIABILITY-ADMITTING APOLOGIES

4.1 Strict Liability Rule: Automated assistants and human agents are strictly prohibited from issuing apologies that express or imply legal fault, negligence, or admission of liability on behalf of Kartway Corporation or its marketplace vendors.
4.2 Permitted Expression: Expressing empathy for an inconvenience is permitted (e.g., *"We regret the delay with your delivery"*).
4.3 Prohibited Expression: Agents and systems must never state or imply that Kartway caused the underlying failure through negligence (e.g., prohibited phrases include: *"Our warehouse made a mistake"*, *"We were careless with your package"*, or *"Kartway is legally responsible for this defect"*). Product liability assessments remain the sole purview of the Legal Response Operations Unit.